

Earthquake Prep 101

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Let's be honest, preparing for a disaster isn't the most exciting way to spend a Saturday. No one is going to blame you for not having a go bag or a stockpile of water and batteries handy. We're busy in the rat race and whatever free time we have is spent in a futile attempt to relax before returning to the grind.

But, if you live in a seismically-active zone you're likely scolded by the media that the big one is coming and the statistical probability that you're not prepared.

Let's change that.

We'll get to what to have on hand shortly, but remember that after a disaster strikes we are not immediately thrust into a Hunger Games-style post-apocalyptic playground just yet. Surviving the actual disaster is predominantly luck, but surviving the infrastructure fallout requires skill and supplies. Gas, water and electricity will likely get knocked out. Depending on where you live, the waiting game for those necessities may take weeks.

So preparing for the big one should be based on a simple philosophy, care for immediate medical needs from the direct effects of the disaster, and then basic rations intended to wait out at least three days without any infrastructure for food, water, heat or power.

This logic is sound and can truly save you from the painful fallout of a city-crumbling 'quake. And this logic will drive the consideration for supplies you should have on hand and available at a moment's notice.

Immediate Actions

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The big one hits. You hunker down either in an inner doorway or under a sturdy piece of furniture. Protect your head and neck with your hands, a book, pillow or anything that can shield you from falling debris.

The dust settles. Stillness.

First, take a deep breath and survey your bodily damage. Are you hurt? Is anything broken? Can you move? Don't spring to your feet just yet. Your adrenaline is pumping so hard that you likely won't feel your femur poking through your skin. So take a visual inventory of your body. Is there any blood? Are all your joints bending in the appropriate directions?

Survey your surroundings. Is there structural damage to your home? Are you trapped? If it appears safe to move around the home, immediately shut off your gas and electricity. There is a very real possibility that your gas line severed somewhere in the home and you need to mitigate the chance of an explosion.

Now do a wellness check on the rest of your family. Are they safe? Next, grab your medical bag and keep it at arm's length for the next few hours. Everyone will be disoriented and likely not aware of any injuries, you don't want to have to scramble to find bandage wrap once the shock dissipates.

Medical Supplies



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There are many preassembled first aid kits available like [this one](http://rdcrss.org/1J01S1z) (<http://rdcrss.org/1J01S1z>) from the Red Cross. The item list can get lengthy so we'll save you from a never-ending bullet pointed list.

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What you need most in your medical supplies are items that can properly clean, sterilize and wrap wounds. Bandages, Neosporin, hydrogen peroxide, splints and gauze as well as medical tape that can help with compression should all be in your preparedness kit. Scissors, tweezers and latex gloves are just as important. And even if you have a multi-purpose tool in your kit, which you should, don't think that you should use that when tending to an open wound.

It may be difficult to maintain a supply of prescription drugs in a preparedness kit but the [Red Cross](http://rdcrss.org/1J01S1z) advises (<http://rdcrss.org/1J01S1z>) to have at least a week's worth of prescriptions available. If the big one hits, you're not going to be able to run to the pharmacy any time soon.

Equipment



Your main priorities for equipment are heat, light and safety. If you live in southern California, heat likely won't be an issue, but be sure to include enough blankets for the family as winters in LA can still dip near freezing at night. Battery powered lights have come a long way in the past few decades. LED camping lanterns can run for hours on a few D batteries, which are great for general illumination. But headlamps are a must. Headlamps are those little LED lights attached to a headband. Have at least enough for everyone in the family, because you don't want to be lugging a lantern every time you go out to relieve yourself.

Speaking of relieving yourself, the dirty business that gets flushed away in a fully functional society is going to hang around a bit. At least until the water starts running again, you're going to have to dispose of your own waste.

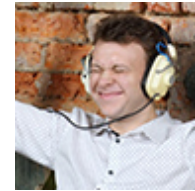
Some companies offer five-gallon buckets with special toilet seat lids. This can be useful but remember that without running water, you won't be able to wash out that bucket so easily. A small shovel can be a life saver in many ways, and helping you dispose of your waste is on the top of that list.

The Russian military has the [perfect shovel](http://amzn.to/1H98Vrg) (<http://amzn.to/1H98Vrg>) for the job. It is small, sharp edged, and easy to carry if you find yourself on the move after a disaster. The sharp edge can be used as a makeshift axe if needed. Some models even have a serrated edge for use as a



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We all dream of finding the perfect home. We obsess over the number of bedrooms, being close to good schools, and the



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Few things are permanent in this disposable culture of ours. But it's still hard to believe how quickly to-



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ow's

(<http://homeliving101.com/lifestyle/trimming-the-fringe-of-suburbia/>)

There is no more potent image of American prosperity than a sprawling tree-lined street filled with large single-family homes. In a word: suburbia - born...

rudimentary saw.

Rations

Be sure to keep a trove of dry food, non-perishables and enough water so each person has a gallon a day for at least three days. For a family of four that's 12 gallons, which may seem like a burden to store, and it will take up a sizeable amount of storage space. But that water will be your lifeline during the fallout of a disaster before the utilities are restored.

Takeaway

Find a corner of a closet and dedicate it to your preparedness trove. Be thankful every day that you don't have to use it, and rest easy because you are as prepared as you can be for the big one. It's only a matter of time before southern California is hit with a life changing earthquake disaster. You owe it to you and yours to be as prepared as possible.

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